AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

AI Is Changing Work, Task by Task

What exactly has changed in how my team works?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 3 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

The most useful place to understand AI's effect on work is not the whole role – it's the task, and the process inside it.

The output still looks the same. The work behind it doesn't – and you're accountable for the part you can no longer see.

1 Was your model built before AI – or after?

Think about one task your team does regularly – a first draft, a research summary, a weekly status update, a client email. You have a mental model of how it gets made: the steps, the time it takes, the skills it calls for, what a good version looks like. You built that model over time, from observation and experience. The question is: was it built before AI, or after? If before – and for most managers it was – something important may have shifted underneath it: gradually, invisibly, and without anyone telling you. The shift has three parts: it happens at the **task level**, it happens **in the process**, and it lands **unevenly**.

2 Task level – inside the job, not the whole role

Whole-role questions – will this job still exist? – are already real in some fields. But for most managers, the more immediate and useful place to look is inside the role, at the tasks that make up the work. AI rarely shows up as a whole new job; it reaches into specific pieces – drafting a section, summarising a document, pulling together research – and changes how that piece gets done. Picture any role as a bundle of tasks: a team lead drafts updates, prepares analysis, runs one-to-ones, reviews others' work. AI might reshape the drafting and the analysis while leaving the one-to-ones and the judgment inside those reviews largely untouched. The job title stays the same while, one task at a time, the work changes.

3 In the process – where you can't see it

Any piece of work runs on the same simple shape: **Input** (what goes in) → **Process** (the steps that turn it into a result) → **Output** (what comes out). AI changes the process – often significantly, often in ways that never surface in the output. The slow part of a task can collapse to a fraction of what it took, while the judgment that matters – what to include, what the reader actually needs, which risk to flag – stays exactly where it was, or matters more than before.

Newer tools push even more of the work into that invisible middle. A simple AI chat helps with one visible step; an **agentic tool** takes a broader goal and moves through several steps – research, selection, drafting, checking – before the result appears. The more of the process AI handles, the less the finished output tells you about how the work was made. This is how the gap between the manager's picture and the team's reality opens – without anyone announcing it.

4 Uneven – it hits people differently

Inside "my team uses AI," the variation is significant – and it is not random. Sorting people into users and non-users explains very little. Two dimensions matter most, because managers usually see one and miss the other. The first is **willingness** – the enthusiastic adopter, the reluctant one, the person who tried it once and went back. It matters, but it doesn't explain the whole pattern. The second is **task fit**, the one that gets missed: AI is strong on structured writing, summarising, first drafts, and processing information – weak on nuanced judgment, relationship work, and decisions that need deep context.

> **TERM – JAGGED FRONTIER**
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> The boundary between where AI helps and where it doesn't is uneven and hard to predict – and it doesn't track job title, seniority, or willingness.

That's why two people with the same job title can have completely different experiences: the actual mix of tasks they spend their days on usually differs, and the frontier runs through each mix differently. Task fit sits alongside other conditions – access, time, confidence, trust, whether it's expected of them. Treat all of it as willingness, and you'll misread what's happening.

TRY IT – PRESSURE-TEST ONE MENTAL MODEL

1. Pick one task your team does regularly – a first draft, a research summary, a status update.
2. Walk through how you believe it gets made: the steps, the time, the skills, what good looks like.
3. Ask yourself when you built that picture – before AI, or after? Then ask the person who does the task how it's made today.

Why the last step matters: the change doesn't show in the output, so asking is the only way to see it – and most managers haven't asked yet.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Stop reasoning about AI at the level of **whole roles** – look inside the job, task by task.
- Expect the change **in the process, not the output** – finished work will keep looking normal.
- Read variation across your team as **task fit and conditions**, not just willingness – the users/non-users binary explains little.
- Treat your mental model of how the work gets made as **dated until checked** – and check by asking, not by inspecting outputs.

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.4 – Why This Matters for You as a Manager** – what the change means for you, and the structured response the rest of the course is built on.